

RICK ASHFORD

Director, Sales Engineering

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Sales engineering executive with 17+ years building and leading high-performance SE organizations across North America and Latin America, inside a 27-year career in technology. Proven track record driving measurable revenue outcomes — growing strategic partner bookings from single-digit to double-digit millions and sustaining employee eNPS above 90. Expert at designing and executing the full technical pre-sales motion from discovery through proof-of-concept to close, while developing talent that reaches elite individual performance. Combines deep technical expertise in enterprise infrastructure, cloud platforms, Kubernetes, and container security with executive-level communication and business acumen. Bilingual in English and Portuguese.

CORE COMPETENCIES

Technical Pre-Sales Leadership	Team Development & Player-Coach Model	MEDDPICC Sales Methodology
Revenue Growth & Partner Ecosystems	Enterprise Cloud & Container Platforms	Cross-Functional GTM Strategy
Solution Architecture & POC Design	Talent Recruiting & SE Mentorship	Bilingual (English / Portuguese)

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Director of Solution Architects, North American Ecosystem • **SUSE** • Nov 2022 – Nov 2025 • *Remote*

- Drove significant revenue growth across top strategic partners over two years: CDW grew from \$8M to \$17M, WWT from \$2M to \$4.5M, and Presidio from ~\$100K to \$2M — achieved through deepened executive relationships, aligned technical resources, and jointly developed go-to-market motions.
- Designed and deployed a standardized partner demo framework adopted across all US-based channel and reseller partners — enabling lower-proficiency partners to deliver compelling, on-message demonstrations without deep product investment, while accelerating time-to-demo for advanced partners who previously built their own from scratch.
- Recruited, mentored, and developed a solution architect to SUSE SE of the Year within three years — a direct result of deliberate coaching investment and structured performance development.
- Led technical enablement for three acquired product lines (Rancher, NeuVector, StackState), designing partner-facing readiness content that translated new acquisitions into revenue-producing ecosystem capabilities across the channel.
- Defined and executed the North American ecosystem go-to-market technical strategy across Channel & Distribution Partners, Cloud and Managed Service Providers, and Global Systems Integrators — serving as senior technical voice and escalation point for complex partner integrations.
- Partnered with Product and Engineering to translate field learnings and ecosystem feedback into actionable roadmap input, influencing platform direction based on real-world deployment challenges across the partner network.

Sales Engineering Manager, Western/Central US & LATAM • **SUSE** • May 2016 – Nov 2022 • *Round Rock, TX*

- Built and led a team of 18 sales engineers across North America (10) and LATAM (8) — recruiting and developing talent that produced four SUSE SE of the Year honorees over the tenure.
- Hit 100% of quota or higher every year across the region, driven by disciplined MEDDPICC-based pipeline qualification, rigorous forecast management, and consistent technical execution at the field level.
- Led the technical pre-sales motion for a then-company-record \$20M, three-year enterprise deal — personally orchestrating solution design, proof-of-concept delivery, and executive alignment from first engagement through close.

- Co-created and delivered Expert Days, SUSE's highest-performing global marketing event series — presenting at 10 North American events and contributing to 20 additional sessions worldwide, reaching audiences of 20 to 100 technical and business decision-makers per event.
- Sustained employee eNPS above 90 across the region, reflecting a team culture built on high standards paired with genuine investment in people — and retained the team through it: four departures across nine years of management, only one for performance.
- Partnered with a major aerospace company to develop a STIG and auditing schema enabling classified workloads to run on SUSE Linux — a strategic win that expanded SUSE's footprint in defense and regulated industries.
- Qualified for President's Club as a sales engineering manager, recognized for both personal contribution and regional team performance against aggressive targets.
- Represented SUSE as a speaker at SUSECon five times, covering BTRFS, image building with Kiwi, and PaaS with Cloud Foundry — reinforcing the player-coach model by staying technically active and field-credible alongside the team.

Technical Sales Specialist • SUSE • Aug 2008 – May 2016 • Austin, TX

- Twice achieved then-company-record deal sizes as an individual contributor — demonstrating consistent ability to win complex, high-value enterprise opportunities in competitive environments.
- Qualified for President's Club four times as an individual contributor across an eight-year tenure, reflecting sustained top-quartile performance and persistent pipeline contribution.
- Represented SUSE at the OpenStack Summit three times, establishing technical credibility in the open infrastructure community and expanding SUSE's visibility among enterprise cloud decision-makers.
- Delivered hands-on pre-sales expertise for enterprise solutions including SUSE Linux, OpenStack, and emerging container technologies — conducting live demos, proofs-of-concept, and solution workshops for Fortune 500 clients.
- Built trusted, long-term customer relationships through consistent technical excellence and solution advocacy, directly contributing to record-setting pipeline and market share growth.

Deployment Engineer / Sales Engineer → Manager of Operations • Catalis, Inc. • Jan 2004 – Dec 2007 • Austin, TX

Healthcare IT startup delivering electronic medical records (EMR) systems to clinical practices. Fluid startup roles — deployment engineering and sales engineering were the same job.

- Rescued a deal the company could not deliver: a rep closed business on an ASP (hosted) deployment model Catalis had not planned to build for another two years. Built the virtual machine hosting environment that made it real — generating \$200K+ in new sales within three months and strengthening the investor pitch. Then built the sales engineering function from nothing so a rep could never again sell a product that did not exist.
- Automated server build procedures, reducing build time from 8–12 hours to 1–2 hours and cutting customer-impacting issues by 95% — a foundational infrastructure improvement that scaled delivery capacity without additional headcount.
- Standardized implementation procedures through checklists, best-practice documentation, and post-mortem reviews — reducing average clinic installation time from 2–3 days on-site to just 4 hours.
- As Manager of Operations (final months), oversaw IT, network operations, training, support, and account management — saving four at-risk clinic accounts worth \$300K in immediate revenue and ~\$5K/month recurring.

EDUCATION

Master of Information Technology — American InterContinental University, 2003

Bachelor of Arts, Near Eastern Studies — Brigham Young University, 2001

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Cloud Platforms:	AWS, Azure, GCP
Container & Orchestration:	Kubernetes, Rancher, K3s, Harvester, Docker, NeuVector (container security)
Enterprise Infrastructure:	SUSE Linux Enterprise, OpenStack, HPC, Storage, ARM architectures, VMware
Configuration Management:	Salt, Ansible, Chef, Puppet
DevOps & CI/CD:	Git, Jenkins, CI/CD pipelines
Sales Tools:	Salesforce, Gong, MEDDPIC methodology

Languages:

English (Native), Portuguese (Full Professional Proficiency)